



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
NORTHWESTERN KELLOGG

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ABOUT THE SCHOOL

The Kellogg School of Management is part of Northwestern University, located in Evanston about 12 miles north of downtown Chicago. The beautiful lakeside location in a thriving student town is a big part of the Kellogg culture, with time to cultivate strong ties with classmates that is so much part of the school's close-knit community. The collaborative learning style of the MBA program reinforces these ties, with a heavy emphasis on teamwork – 'we' rather than 'I.'

Stereo-typed as the school for marketing, Kellogg is in fact so much more. Energized by the arrival of Dean Sally Blount, the school looks for strong quant skills to underpin sharp analytical skills. So why does McKinsey recruit more Kellogg MBAs than any other U.S. school? Because they have humility, great analytical skills, and the people skills that mean they can be client facing from day one.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Marketing, general management, non-profit/social responsibility, production/operations, strategy, entrepreneurship, healthcare, consumer goods

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 4,595 MBA Class Size: 478
Admissions Selectivity: 20.7% Yield: 50.25%
Total Tuition: \$143,088

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Consulting 30%; Technology 28%; Financial Services 14%; Consumer Products 7%
Top Recruiters: McKinsey, Bain, BCG, Deloitte Consulting
Avg. Base Salary: \$128,192 Employment in 3 months: 95%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	5	5	7	3	9	9	8	10
Financial Times	9	8	9	8	11	12	8	9
Forbes	–	5	3	–	4	–		3
The Economist	13	15	12	6	2	–	2	3
US News	4	4	6	6	5	4	6	6

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 28 yrs Avg. GMAT: 732 Avg. GPA: 3.6
Int'l Students: 34% Female Students: 46%

Deadlines for 2018-2019: R1- Sep 18, '19 R2- Jan 8, '20 R3- Apr 8, '20

COVID-19 changes (announced 3/16/20)

The Kellogg Future Leaders deadline moves back two months to June 3 & the GMAT/GRE requirement is "completely optional" for KFL applicants. R3 applicants may submit without exams; exam scores will be due May 1. Kellogg pledges to work with each applicant who may be unable to submit a test score by May 1, and potentially push the decision to June. Those still unable to take exams can transfer their application to next year.

Sources: Northwestern Kellogg, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, US News, MBA50



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ESSAYS 2020

This year, Kellogg replaced its second required essay. Fortuna's Jason Yeh, former Kellogg Admissions Interviewer and Kellogg MBA alum, offers his tips on tackling the essays.

Required essays:

1. Kellogg's purpose is to educate, equip & inspire brave leaders who create lasting value. Tell us about a time you have demonstrated leadership and created lasting value. What challenges did you face, and what did you learn? (450 words)

2. Values are what guide you in your life and work. What values are important to you and how have they influenced you? (450 words)

Let's start decoding, piece-by-piece.

ESSAY 1 DECODED

"Kellogg's purpose is to educate, equip and inspire brave leaders who create lasting value."

To unpack the opening statement: What the question is asserting here is that walking through Kellogg's door means that you're not only going to receive a world-class MBA, but you're also expected to add value by engaging in the classroom, the greater community and, ultimately, the world as a Kellogg alum. How will you drive the type of MBA experience that leaves your classmates wishing they had more time with you? The MBA experience is only as unique as the collective contribution of the class, and this means that Kellogg is trying to uncover your capacity to lead and participate in this collective experience during school and beyond.

"Provide a recent example where you have demonstrated leadership and created value."

This part is directed at your specific leadership experience. Kellogg is trying to get a sense of who you are as a leader, and how you've shaped the organizations and communities in which you're involved. The words to pay attention to are "created lasting value." (This notion is so important it's mentioned twice in the same prompt.) This is your opportunity to tell a story. Think through – why must you tell this story? How is the world better off from you having told this story? What leadership experiences can you share that reveal you've succeeded in elevating people, places and/or circumstances because of your conscious participation? What story will illuminate the significance of this shift, showcasing the situation before you came in, while you were there and after you've left?

"What challenges did you face and what did you learn?"

This is both the substance and resolution of your story. Who are the characters of your story? What setting are you in? What are the stakes of you not succeeding in your leadership challenge? How did you grow through the challenge? Don't just share what you learned and stop there; essays that nail this question will also demonstrate how what you learned will translate to your unique contribution towards the Kellogg class of 2021, during your MBA and beyond.



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ESSAY 2 DECODED

“Values are what guide you in your life and work.”

Your values aren't a laundry list of adjectives, they're emblematic of the beliefs that guide your decisions, actions and engagement in the things that matter most to you. Similar to Stanford GSB's iconic 'what matters most to you and why' essay, Kellogg is looking to know what it is that inspires, drives and motivates you. Candidates who do the thoughtful introspection required to write with authenticity and substance will deliver a valuable view into who they are as a person, not just the inner workings of a dazzling intellect. Your values inherently extend beyond yourself, into your relationships with people and the places where you imagine making a positive impact.

“What values are important to you and how have they influenced you?”

This is an opportunity to tell a story that's personal, vulnerable and honest. You might lead with one specific value and the emblematic story that helps connect the dots between what has shaped you and who you've become. As you look back, what are the seminal moments, influences and interactions that have forged you into an ever-wiser human being? Has anything rocked you to the core, prompting you to rethink the path you'd charted for yourself? This can be anything from the loss of a family member to a horrible mistake or a failure that illuminated what's most essential for you.

Another tact is to lead with an origin story, the background of your childhood or the environment that shaped you. Then, how have those forces and experiences informed the person you are today and your aspirations for the future? The way to really nail this essay question is to coherently connect past, present and future. How will your values and perspectives influence the type of experience you create for your future Kellogg classmates? For the win: how will this accumulated wisdom inform the type of leader you will become in the longer term?

VIDEO ESSAY DECODED

Lastly, Kellogg asks each applicant to complete a video essay component after submitting the application. This year, the school gives you two of the three questions upfront. The first asks you to 'introduce yourself to the admissions committee' in the spirit of what you'll bring to future classmates and 'what makes you, you?'. The second drives at your career goals and 'why Kellogg.' The third is randomly generated with the objective of understanding how 'you handled a challenging situation in your career or personal life.'

Consider this video component is a huge opportunity to showcase your personality. As you prepare, imagine how to convey what's not obvious in your resume, credentials or LinkedIn profile. What will help make your application sticky and memorable? Again, reflect on the story you want to tell and offer a dimension that might be missing.

Play with ways to take advantage of the medium itself in your storytelling. Among my favorite efforts at a 'introduce yourself' video response was from a candidate who gave a brief viola performance, then used an element of the instrument itself as a metaphor to convey his personality and interpersonal style.



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5 Top Tips to Performing Well on the Video Essays:

1. Plan your answers. Jot down a few bullets or talking points or outline a quick structure, e.g., main answer and supporting examples. But avoid overly scripting – you want to appear fluid and natural on camera.
2. Stand for more energy.
3. Record yourself when you practice. What type of impression are you giving off? Are you friendly and approachable? Would others feel comfortable working with you?
4. Don't forget to smile. When you enjoy yourself, it shines through and makes a connection with the viewer (you're on camera, after all).
5. Visualize success. Ask yourself, if the person reviewing my video essay takes nothing else, what is the number one thing I want them to remember about me?

The key to delivering a series of standout essays to Kellogg is to embrace your genuine story. Do this successfully, and you'll be embraced in return: Among Kellogg's signature traditions during MBA orientation is the moment when the Dean of Admissions offers a rousing speech called "One of You," which runs down a list of remarkable highlights about new students. What this means for MBA candidates is that there's a place for you based on your true, authentic self. Weaving an authentically crafted narrative that conveys your passions and clarity of purpose – in a way that elicits emotional impact – this is the secret sauce in creating a connection to an admission reader's heart.



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Tip #1 - Play to your strengths . . . even if they seem conventional

Kellogg prides itself on building a truly diverse class across lots of dimensions. One of the signature traditions during orientation is for the Dean of Admissions to give a speech called "One of You" that runs down a list of remarkable highlights about new students. What this means for applicants is that there is a place for you based on your true, authentic self. In fact, officers take great pride in identifying candidates who have really self-reflected on what they want and how Kellogg will get them there. The key is to embrace your genuine story even if it seems entirely normal – failing to do so trips up more applicants than you can imagine. If you've taken a traditional path in banking because that's your interest, then own that. After all, an entire class can't be filled by Peace Corps workers who started their own microfinance funds and sing professionally on the side. And if you try to spice up your application with details or stories that read falsely, officers will sniff them out immediately.

Tip #2 - Differentiate yourself based on your conventions

In fact, Kellogg has become so diverse that more conventional paths can stand out. This is particularly true if you're coming from finance with plans to potentially stay in that industry or make a pivot from, say, private equity to investment banking. There is concern in some quarters that the program has embraced the poets at the expense of the quants. While this reflects a shift amongst the applicant pool (and the broader decline of interest in finance as the prestige MBA path), the school is very much attuned to applicants with a linear story and exceptional quant skills.

Tip #3 - Recognize that culture really does matter – and know what that means

As the Kellogg culture has become more deeply ingrained, the need to preserve it has heightened. Officers feel a real sense of obligation to protect what makes the school unique. Almost every aspect of the application has some component geared toward understanding if a student is the right fit. So what exactly does this culture of collaboration entail? Dean Blount expresses it as impact without ego, and that's about as good a definition as exists. Another way to think about the culture is like this: the program will force you to work in team settings constantly. Most people can be dependable peers for an hour at a time. But what if you're in hour 12 of an intense case analysis? Do you still have the maturity to be just as diplomatic as in hour 1? Or, if the problem with coming to an answer is that everyone in the group wants to be the leader, do you have the poise to switch roles and become the facilitator needed to get everyone on the same page? A strong applicant will show strong situational awareness and examples of how they can work in lots of different types of teams.

Tip #4 - Remember that culture isn't a synonym for fun

The most obvious part of the Kellogg culture from the moment you set foot on campus is the collegiality amongst the students. The mistake many applicants make is to treat those as the same or comprehensive of the total experience. Kellogg's social scene is definitely a big part of its appeal, but the culture runs much deeper than that and of course it's still a lot of hard work. Many applicants trip up by anchoring too heavily on their intended extracurricular involvement or even touching on their intentions to partake in the party scene. Even if your friends at Kellogg want to focus on how they're having the time of their lives and take you out the night before your interview, officers are looking for evidence of maturity and want to make sure you know you're prepared to put in a lot of effort. Personality matters, but so does professionalism. After all, if you're admitted in just a few short months you'll be conducting a similar interview for jobs – and representing the brand.

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Tip #5 - Don't let the marketing reputation fool you

Kellogg is one of the more diversified MBA programs. While the school is famous for marketing, the reality is that it sends the largest number of its students to consulting. The mix of the general management curriculum and highly specialized concentrations, plus the innovation and teamwork training, create a natural pipeline for top shops like McKinsey. But of course those skills speak to just about every industry and function. In fact, just to build on the fact that conventional profiles can actually stand out, job opportunities in finance are plentiful at the school. There's quite frankly less competition for those positions than at Wharton or Booth, and the same companies hire. There have been whispers in recent years of recruiters from financial institutions getting frustrated at not filling all their quotas from Kellogg.

Tip #6 - Tell a good story

This doesn't mean embellish. Quite the opposite, the advice here is to aim for consistency in putting together your application with clear threads throughout. Since Kellogg prides itself on providing a transformative and aspirational experience, candidates can easily go off the rails. You definitely want to aim high, but make sure the supporting elements are solid. Do your essays and letters of recommendation define a similar vision? Do your letters of recommendation and interview paint a similar portrait? Do your undergrad experiences line up with your essays? Candidates can sometimes get a little carried away, which leads to big dreams that don't seem based in any previous experiences.

Tip #7 - Have a viable alternative

Perhaps the most oft-cited critique or question from a Kellogg officer: "does this person have a plan b?" That's another way of saying that the story didn't quite come together and that the ending in particular is concerning. In the high-stakes rankings game, Kellogg has done well in large part with the employment record of a large percentage of its graduates. The careers staff do a phenomenal job in working with students, but they also don't want to have to take unnecessary risks. To tie this all together with the other tips, if your plan is to start your own company but you have no entrepreneurship anywhere in your background and your recommenders say you're risk-averse, you need to display a viable alternative. And at a school in which competition for a position in consulting is fierce, working for Bain, BCG or McKinsey in order to "round out your experiences and get exposed to lots of different industries" is not a solid backup.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas. As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com.

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school. Our free consultations are consistently rated as the best in the industry. To learn more about Fortuna and assess your chances for admission, reserve yours at: FortunaAdmissions.com

